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AHEAD OF PM'S LIKELY VISIT IN DEC

Trade in focus, India, Canada push to up ties

To take ties to higher level, says Jaishankar; building renewed partnerships with large economies like India, China: Canada minister

Divya A
New Delhi, September 27

SIGNALLING FURTHER moves to improve ties between New Delhi and Ottawa, Canada's Foreign Minister Anita Anand underlined attempts to build "renewed partnerships" with large economies like India and China, while External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said the two sides are preparing to take their relationship "to a higher level".

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



EAM S Jaishankar with his Canadian counterpart Anita Anand in New York. ANI

As fungal disease hits sugar output in UP, new cane variety holds hope

Harish Damodaran
New Delhi, September 27

UTTAR PRADESH, India's top cane growing state, has seen its sugar output plummet from 126.4 lakh tonnes (lt) to 89.5 lt between 2019-20 and 2025-26 (October-September production years).

The primary reason has been the susceptibility of the

widely-cultivated sugarcane variety, Co-0238 (also called Karan 4), to red rot fungal disease.

The resultant yield losses have led to the total quantity of cane crushed by the 120-odd sugar mills in Uttar Pradesh, where Assembly elections are set to be held in February-March 2027, falling by over a fifth in the last six years.

A new variety of hope

The industry is now pinning its hopes on a new variety developed by the Indian Council of Agricultural Research's Sugarcane Breeding Institute (ICAR-SBI) at Coimbatore. This variety, Co-20016 (Karan 20), has already been picked as a potential replacement for Co-0238 by a Varietal Identification Committee

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Canada

This comes ahead of a proposed visit by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Canada in December this year, when the two sides are aiming to finalise and sign the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA).

Jaishankar met Anand on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) on Saturday. "Always a pleasure to meet FM @AnitaAnandMP of Canada... A productive discussion as we prepare to take the relationship to a higher level," he said in a post on X, as he shared a short video clip of their meeting.

Meanwhile, in her address at the high-level UNGA General Debate on Saturday, Anand said that in the economic realm, Canada is focused on what it can control: diversifying its trade and catalysing a trillion dollars of investment in the country over the next five years.

Shesaid for this, Ottawa is exploring new opportunities with

partners in the Indo-Pacific, the Gulf region and Latin America. "This includes building renewed partnerships with large economies like India and China," she said.

Anand also highlighted efforts with India and other nations to strengthen multilateralism and boost UN reforms. Earlier this week, India co-sponsored an inaugural multilateralism summit at the UN headquarters, with Australia, Barbados, Brazil, Canada and Kenya.

While New Delhi and Ottawa have hit a major reset in ties ever since Canadian Prime Minister Mike Carney took over in March 2025, both sides are also aiming at strategic autonomy and trade diversification in the wake of trade and tariff pressures from Washington.

Earlier this week, Carney said at the UN that Modi was expected to visit Canada around December this year. "We are making good progress in our trade negotiations with India. It is an exceptionally important relationship on many levels, people-to-people levels, security

levels, and also trade and economic," he said at a press conference Tuesday on the sidelines of the UNGA.

India and Canada had committed at the G20 last year to "look to conclude negotiations by the G20 this year", he said, while responding to questions on when Modi would visit Canada and how close Ottawa was to concluding a free trade agreement with India.

Ties between the two countries had nosedived in 2023, during the tenure of former prime minister Justin Trudeau, after he said that Canadian security agencies were pursuing allegations of a potential link between agents of the Indian government and the killing of Canadian citizen Hardeep Singh Nijjar in British Columbia — a claim rejected by India.

The diplomatic row led to reciprocal expulsions of diplomats and a reduction in diplomatic personnel.

In July this year, the Royal Canadian Mounted Police — as part of a larger investigation into transnational organised crime — said it had found no evidence

linking Indian government officials to Nijjar's killing.

In June last year, Carney and Modi agreed to take calibrated steps to restore stability, followed by the return of high commissioners and a series of high-level engagements.

Modi visited Canada for the G7 Summit last year. If he travels to Canada in December, it will be his first bilateral visit to the country after 2015.

Carney made a bilateral visit to India from February 27 to March 2 this year -- the first visit by a Canadian Prime Minister to the country since 2018.

The two sides have been in touch at various levels — including several rounds of discussions and meetings between Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and Canadian Minister of International Trade Maninder Sidhu. Goyal said earlier that the two sides have agreed to fast-track negotiations for a comprehensive economic partnership, with the next round of talks scheduled to begin on October 5.

The agreement is engineered to expand bilateral trade to \$50 billion by 2030. WITH PTI INPUTS

UP sugar

under the All-India Coordinated Research Project (AICRP) on Sugarcane, which met on May 27. "It will next be placed before the Central Varietal Release Committee, which is expected to meet in October. Once approved by it and officially released for commercial cultivation, farmers can plant the variety in the coming spring (February-March), summer (April-May), or autumn (mid-September to mid-November) seasons," said a government official.

The Indian Sugar & Bio-energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) had, in August 2023, launched a joint initiative with the ICAR-SBI for conducting evaluation trials of improved cane varieties at selected factory locations across both subtropical (UP, Uttarakhand, Bihar, Haryana and Punjab) and tropical (Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana) India.

For the subtropical region, the clones of two varieties (Co-20016 and Co-21012) were tested over three years through two plant-cane and one ratoon crops. Sixteen sugar mills participated in the trials, including 11 from UP. "We have completed the trials for both the varieties and the results are very encour-

E. EXPLAINED

Behind the rot

For nearly a decade, a single blockbuster cane variety, Co-0238, made UP India's top sugar producer, overtaking Maharashtra. But devastating red rot fungal attacks, from its monocropping, have led both mills and farmers to look for an alternative high-yielding, disease-resistant variety.

aging," ISMA's Director General Deepak Ballani said. The AICRP trials under ICAR have also been completed for Co-20016, and are in progress for Co-21012.

The three-year average cane yield for Co-20016 at ISMA's trial locations worked out to 144.6 tonnes per hectare, as against 116.4 tonnes for Co-0238. The mean sucrose content in the cane juice at 10-months cropping period, too, was found higher for Co-20016 (18.7%) than for Co-0238 (18.3%).

Red rot resistance

More important, the Co-20016 variety has shown to be resistant to red rot — specifically the highly virulent 'CF13' pathotype of the Colletotrichum falcatum fungal pathogen.

When Co-0238 was developed by ICAR-SBI and released

● CANE & SUGAR IN U.P. MILLS (lakh tonnes)			
	Sugarcane crushed	Sugar production	Sugar recovery
2011-12	768.55	69.74	9.07%
2012-13	815.06	74.85	9.18%
2013-14	701.17	64.95	9.26%
2014-15	744.53	71.01	9.54%
2015-16	645.67	68.55	10.62%
2016-17	827.16	87.73	10.61%
2017-18	1,111.90	120.5	10.84%
2018-19	1,031.67	118.22	11.49%
2019-20	1,118.02	126.37	11.73%
2020-21	1,027.50	110.59	11.46%
2021-22	1,016.26	101.98	11.47%
2022-23	1,098.82	104.82	11.4%
2023-24	981.68	104.13	11.5%
2024-25	956.09	92.45	10.68%
2025-26	878.12	89.52	10.83%

NOTE: SUGAR RECOVERY RATES ARE WITHOUT DIVERSION TO B-HAVY MOLASSES. SOURCE: SUGAR INDUSTRY & CANE DEVELOPMENT DEPARTMENT, GOVERNMENT OF UTTAR PRADESH

in 2009, it was evaluated as moderately resistant to the prevalent 'CF07' and 'CF08' pathotypes of the red rot-causing fungus.

"The CF13 pathotype emerged due to the intensive monoculture planting of Co-0238 in UP as well as other subtropical states. As the fungus mutated and evolved into this new pathotype, Co-0238 suffered varietal breakdown, losing its resistance and becoming susceptible to red rot," explained Dr Bakshi Ram, former director of ICAR-SBI and breeder of this once-blockbuster variety.

The contribution of Co-0238 to UP's sugar industry can be seen from the accompanying table.

"For all its advantages, I had warned against the over-cultivation of the variety, especially in the central, eastern and Terai belts of UP that are prone to waterlogging. Waterlogged fields are particularly conducive for red rot infestation and transport of the fungal spores across regions. Unfortunately, neither the mills nor farmers followed my advice," Dr Ram said.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

●

- THE TOP TWO: 76-DAY ADJOURNMENT IN 1987 AND A 61-DAY STRETCH IN 1989 OVER BOFORS SCANDAL

46 days & counting: Monsoon Session is 3rd-longest *sine die* adjournment in history

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, September 27

AT 46 DAYS and counting, the Eighth Session of the 18th Lok Sabha has acquired the distinction of witnessing the third-longest *sine die* adjournment in history, Parliament records show. While the two longest adjournments came during pre-vious Congress governments, this is the longest that Parliament has been adjourned since the BJP-led NDA government first came to power in 2014.

The 2023 Monsoon Session was held from July 21 to August 21, with 21 sittings, and the House was prorogued the following day. The prolonged adjournment comes after a session marked by repeated disruptions over several issues, including NEET paper leak, alleged theft at Ram temple and demands for Union Home Minister Amit Shah to respond to action on youth protesters.

The continued non-prorogation of the House has also fuelled speculation about the possibility of a fresh sitting in October. Political debate has centred on the numbers required for a constitutional amendment linked to delimitation and women's reservation. Claims about the government's

plans, however, are speculative rather than based on established parliamentary decisions.

Under the NDA government, before this, the longest a session went without getting prorogued after being declared adjourned *sine die* is longer than the 28-day period between August 12, 2015 and September 10, 2015, and the 20-day period between August 11 and August 31, 2021.

According to *Practice and Procedure of Parliament* by MN Kaul and SL Shakkher, a House may be adjourned from day to day, for more than a day, or *sine die* during a session.

An adjournment postpones the sitting of the House to another time. When a House is adjourned *sine die*, no date is fixed for its next sitting. The sit-

● ADJOURNMENT HISTORY

Period of Adjournment	Total days
12 May 1987 till 27 July 1987	76 days
18 August 1989 till 11 October 1989 & 13 October 1989 till 20 October 1989	61 days
22 December 1950 till 5 February 1951	45 days
11 December 1962 till 21 January 1963	41 days
13 August 2015 till 10 September 2015	28 days
7 August 1975 till 3 September 1975	27 days
28 August 1993 till 23 September 23	26 days
7 September 1990 till 1 October 1990	24 days
5 September 1988 till 30 September 1988	25 days
16 December 1988 to 5 January 1989	20 days
11 August 2021 till 31 August 2021	20 days
16 July 1979 till 3 August 1979	18 days

PRACTICE AND PROCEDURE OF PARLIAMENT BY M N KAUL AND S L SHAKHDER

ing has ended, but the session itself has not necessarily been terminated.

Prorogation is different. Under Article 85(2) of the Constitution, a session of Parliament is formally terminated by an order of the President. Ordinarily, prorogation follows an adjournment *sine die*, although the two are legally distinct.

The President exercises the power to prorogue Parliament on the advice of the PM.

The Speaker can call a sitting of LS before the date to which it has been adjourned, or at any time after the House has been adjourned *sine die*. This means that an adjournment *sine die* does not, by itself, prevent the House from being reconvened.

The two longest *sine die* ad-

Journalism in LS history occurred during the Eighth Lok Sabha. The longest, lasting 76 days, occurred in 1987 during the Eighth Session of the Eighth Lok Sabha, against the backdrop of Bofors controversy. The second-longest, lasting 61 days, occurred in 1989 during the Fourteenth Session of the same Lok Sabha.

The Eighth Session began on February 23, 1987, and was adjourned *sine die* on May 12 amid disruptions over Bofors. The Speaker exercised the power under the proviso to Rule 15 to reconvene the House from July 27 to August 28. The session continued for several months despite the long gap between sittings. The LS adopted a motion on August 6 to constitute a 30-member JPC to inquire into

The Bofors deal. The RS adopted a corresponding motion on August 12. LS was prorogued on September 3, 1987, bringing the session to an end after the 76-day intervening adjournment.

The Fourteenth Session of the Eighth Lok Sabha began on July 18, 1989, and was adjourned *sine die* on August 18.

The period was marked by another major political confrontation involving Bofors. Around 100 Opposition MPs resigned en masse after a CAG report on the deal was tabled. The Speaker again reconvened the House from October 11 to 16. The House was adjourned *sine die* on October 13 and prorogued on October 20. The intervening period between sittings amounted to 61 days.



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• **XI-TRUMP SUMMIT**

Little to show, much for India to watch

There was no notable outcome from the US-China bilateral summit. But they did agree to a trade truce extension, leaving India vulnerable



ANIL SASI

IT WAS back in 1962 that US President John F Kennedy went to the airport to greet British Prime Minister Harold Macmillan.

For nearly 65 years since then, no sitting American president welcomed a foreign leader arriving in Washington at the airport — until Donald Trump chose to do so for Chinese leader Xi Jinping on September 23, with a military flyover to boot.

The outcome of the summit was underwhelming. The two sides agreed to a two-month extension to their trade truce, which was due to end this November — alongside a new agreement for China to provide two giant pandas to the Atlanta zoo.

The big area that was widely expected to be taken up but was largely passed over was artificial intelligence (AI) safety.

For now, two things are clear from the summit: One, it has done little to assuage concerns on AI; and two, the trade relief for China (albeit only for two months) leaves India facing the prospect of tariffs for buying Russian crude oil.

AI concerns

It was always unlikely that Trump and Xi would come to an agreement on enhancing the monitoring of large language models and possibly place curbs on the pace of AI progress.

The meeting came after a series of incidents in which AI ‘agents’ (systems that work autonomously) went “rogue”. Just days back, it was revealed that an OpenAI agent gained unauthorised access to an Australian government website in June. Now, it has emerged that Open AI agents also meddled with US government websites.

But Trump claimed after the summit that both he and Xi were willing to leave AI exactly where it is. It was Xi who appeared more proactive, claiming that the two sides “should maintain human control of AI”.

Ahead of the meeting, there was talk about a possible hotline between the two countries, and a broad deal for sharing progress reports.

There were some baby steps on both of those issues, but the finer details seemed to have been glossed over.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry said late Saturday the two sides agreed to hold a dialogue on the technology’s risks and benefits, with the next round of discussions slated for November, and to set up a communication link for reporting AI-related incidents. There were no substantive details from either side on either of the two initiatives.

While the Chinese are slightly behind in terms of frontier models and semiconductors, the Americans are behind in terms of the public mindspace on AI.

Surveys show that most Americans are scared of AI and think the technology is going to adversely affect them, while most Chinese favour the use of AI and think it will help them move up in life.

Taiwan

The US has paused the sale of a record \$14-billion arms sale to Taiwan amid Chinese pressure. It is unclear whether that deal will be revived.

According to Derek J Grossman, founder and chief analyst, Indo-Pacific Solutions, the trust deficit between the two sides is too wide to be bridged by the unusual pomp and show at Xi’s arrival in Washington.

“Xi wants the US and China to be ‘partners, not rivals’. Washington wants that too, but the trust deficit and structural constraints — Taiwan, technology, trade, critical minerals, AI, Iran, etc — are deep and abiding,” said Grossman, who is also a professor at the Los Angeles-based USC Dornsife College of Letters, Arts & Sciences.



US President Donald Trump (right) with China’s President Xi Jinping at the White House in Washington, DC on Thursday. AP

Trade tariffs: India’s concerns

Just days before the bilateral summit, on September 18, Trump had signed into law a Bill that allows 100% tariffs on top buyers of Russian energy — primarily China and India.

“On September 23, 2026, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent announced that Washington and Beijing had extended their Busan Agreement until January 10, 2027. During Xi’s visit to Washington, the two sides agreed to avoid new tariffs and trade restrictions on each other,” pointed out Ajay Srivastava, founder of research group Global Trade Research Initiative. The timing matters, he said. The US-China understanding gives Beijing protection while India remains exposed to the tariff threat.

Washington-based analyst Evan A Feigenbaum said he did not expect Trump to go after China under the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026.

“The question for me has been whether he will go after India, which he may believe is a softer target possessed of far fewer retaliatory options. To be blunt about it, the zeitgeist of the past 15 months has been to try to coerce India (which for several months at the end of 2025, was tied with Brazil for the highest American tariffs imposed on any country) while demonstrating repeatedly that the threats to China are mostly rhetorical. Peter Navarro at one point called Ukraine ‘Modi’s war’. Nobody in the administration has ever tried to call it ‘Xi’s war’. And Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent’s comments on the India-EU trade agreement and India’s Russian oil purchases have gone down poorly in New Delhi.”

This US-China summit in Washington, he said, will have “reinforced the suspicion” in India that it is New Delhi in the cross-hairs while Beijing keeps escaping US scrutiny. While India had not signed a trade agreement with the US, both countries agreed on a framework deal in February and released a joint statement.

Srivastava said: “We saw this pattern in July 2025, when Washington spared China but imposed an additional 25% tariff on India for buying Russian crude. If Russian oil purchases are the issue, why does India face the tariff while China gets an exemption? The tariff threat appears aimed at forcing India to cut Russian oil purchases and sign a deeply unequal bilateral trade agreement. Washington could offer a lower rate in return for concessions, but that would give India no lasting certainty. India should not trade its energy security for temporary tariff relief or let US tariff threats dictate its national energy policy.”

A government official, however, told *The Indian Express*: “It’s just two months (the China trade truce extension). The Chinese wanted it till the end of Trump’s term. That hasn’t happened.”

“Our side has also expressed concerns to [Washington] DC over the scope of the sanctions legislation. We will have to see how it goes from here, given that there are discussions on this issue that are coming up at the end of the month (the G20 trade ministers’ meeting in Milwaukee),” said this official, requesting anonymity.

Reading Sino-US signals: ‘Strategic competition’ vs ‘strategic stability’



EXPERT EXPLAINS

G VENKAT RAMAN

PROFESSOR, INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT-INDORE

WHILE US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping’s bilateral summit in Washington, DC has ended with no major breakthrough, the three-day state visit was noticeable for its pageantry and displays of bonhomie between the two leaders. How are the two sides now managing their competition in AI and trade?

What does the unusually elaborate welcome accorded to Xi Jinping say about how Washington now views China?

The elaborate welcome should not be mistaken for reconciliation. It signals recognition that the terms of US-China bargaining have changed. Washington still enjoys substantial advantages in military reach, alliances, global finance, and frontier technologies. But Beijing has demonstrated that it possesses leverage of its own, most visibly through Rare Earths and critical minerals. The tariff confrontation of 2025 showed that economic coercion could impose costs in both directions.

This helps explain the return to summity. Some American analysts go further, arguing that Beijing sees its Rare Earth restrictions as having forced Washington to moderate its approach. But greater bargaining leverage is different from comprehensive parity. The US retains powerful economic and technological instruments, some of which it has chosen not to deploy.

Beijing interprets the changing relationship through “*xianghu zunzhong*” (mutual respect), the expectation that China should be treated as a major power whose interests cannot be overridden at will. The ceremony surrounding Xi’s visit reinforced that message domestically. From Washington’s perspective, however, engagement need not imply acceptance of Beijing’s conception of equality. The narrower conclusion is that China has accumulated sufficient capabilities in critical areas to make sustained coercion costlier, giving both sides stronger reasons to bargain.

Does the summit represent meaningful progress, or does it reveal the continuing fragility of US-China economic relations?

The short trade truce extension captures the paradox of the economic relationship: Washington and Beijing have stepped back from escalation without resolving the disputes that gave rise to it. The truce postpones higher tariffs and keeps negotiations moving, but its limited duration also reflects continuing distrust.

Some US officials and analysts view shorter extensions as checkpoints to assess Chinese implementation, particularly in Rare Earth supplies and agricultural purchases. Beijing had sought a considerably longer arrangement.

Both sides nevertheless have reasons to preserve the pause. The 2025 confrontation demonstrated that restrictions on Rare Earths and magnets could expose vulnerabilities in American supply

chains. Beijing, meanwhile, benefits from a more predictable external environment while confronting domestic economic pressures and continuing to strengthen technological and industrial self-reliance.

This is therefore neither economic normalisation nor decoupling. Tariffs, export controls, and technology restrictions remain available as instruments of leverage even as negotiations, purchase agreements and new mechanisms for commercial engagement create channels for managing disputes.

Beijing presents such engagement through the language of “*huli gongying*” (mutual benefit and win-win cooperation) while Washington emphasises reciprocity and compliance. The emerging pattern is better described as stabilisation without settlement: economic competition continues, but both sides have incentives to prevent it from escalating uncontrollably.

Beijing’s formulation of “*jianshexing zhanlie wending*” (constructive strategic stability) envisages a relationship in which cooperation remains possible, competition is kept within bounds, differences are controlled, and confrontation is avoided. Chinese official commentary contrasts this with what it describes as Washington’s excessive fixation on ‘strategic competition’ and links stability to mutual respect, peaceful coexistence, and win-win cooperation.

Why are Washington and Beijing discussing AI guardrails even as their technological competition intensifies?

The AI dialogue points less to technological convergence than to a shared interest in preventing competition from producing dangerous unintended consequences.

Washington and Beijing remain divided over the foundations of that competition. The US continues to restrict Chinese access to advanced chips and computing capabilities, while Beijing is seeking greater technological self-reliance. Their approaches to AI governance also differ: Xi has emphasised keeping AI under human control, while Trump has resisted regulation that could slow American innovation.

Yet intensifying competition itself creates incentives for communication. The two sides have discussed a notification mechanism for AI incidents with national security implications.

The Chinese position is significant. Beijing argues for dialogue on risks that neither side can manage entirely on its own, even as it continues to pursue greater technological self-reliance. Washington similarly sees room for guardrails without relaxing technological competition.

What are the principal fault lines that remain?

A major unresolved issue is Taiwan. Beijing treats it as a core interest and used the summit to press Washington to move from saying it “does not support” Taiwan independence towards explicitly opposing it. Washington did not make that shift, while questions over future US arms sales remain a potential source of friction. The disagreement, therefore, reaches beyond terminology to the boundaries each side wants strategic stability to observe.

Technology presents another test. Dialogue over AI risks has not removed US restrictions on advanced chips or Beijing’s drive for technological self-reliance.

There is also a wider disagreement over the Asian security order. Beijing used the visit to emphasise its positions on Japan and regional security, while Washington has not abandoned its alliances or commitments in the region.

• **ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE**

From Nepal to India, how AI is aiding disaster management

Amitabh Sinha

New Delhi, September 27

DURING THE recent Nepal disaster, an artificial intelligence (AI)-powered web portal, which could match crowdsourced data on missing persons with official lists of the dead and injured, came into widespread use. The simple tool developed by Niraj Bhushal, an IT engineer in Nepal’s Finance Ministry, also did the important work of mapping damaged buildings.

Similarly, private drone operator Manish Maharjan flew drones equipped with thermal cameras that could detect human-shaped thermal signatures in the debris and guide rescue teams to those potentially trapped.

These efforts illustrate the growing utility of new technology, particularly AI-enabled tools, in disaster management.

Growing utility and use

Disaster management is no longer confined to designated authorities. Companies like Google, telecom providers, satellite companies, and others are now integral players.

“The big advantage of the AI tools is their ability to process large volumes of data in a meaningful way, using natural language, speech and video, on an almost real-time basis. In disaster management situations, time is the most vital thing. That is the main reason why we are seeing increasing reliance on AI tools... It’s a great use-case scenario,” said Subimal Ghosh, head of the Centre for Climate Studies at IIT Bombay, who is using AI to provide local forecasts of heavy rain-fall events in Mumbai.

Numerous AI-enabled tools have been developed and deployed of late, which provide services such as early warning, hazard mapping, and satellite imagery. AI is being integrated across disaster management.

Early warning

One of the most effective uses of AI has been in generating timely forecasts and early warnings. In general, weather forecasting is an inexact science. Forecasters routinely run hundreds of physics equations to arrive at weather forecasts. The more local or time-constrained a forecast, the greater the uncertainty.

AI produces weather forecasts differently: AI models trained on vast amounts of past weather data ‘learn’ how the atmosphere behaves and churn out forecasts much faster.

“It is very difficult to get hyperlocal forecasts by just working on physics equations. It requires a huge amount of computing resources, and usually takes a lot of time. But once an AI model has been trained effectively, very hyperlocal forecasts also become possible in almost real-time,” Ghosh said.

For instance, Google’s Flood Hub takes data from leading weather agencies worldwide and uses a prediction model. This was first used during floods in India in 2018 to forecast flooding events. It can generate advisories up to seven days earlier.

But the forecast needs to be combined with hazard maps to make a risk assessment. This is where AI shines. It can process multiple datasets from different agencies to provide an overall threat assessment for issuing early warning.

Response, relief and rescue

This stage has been traditionally dependent on human intervention and access to physical resources, like helicopters, but AI is now making its presence felt. Since everyone can now broadcast visuals via smartphones and, increasingly, drones, they act as force multipliers, producing large amounts of data.

The ability of AI tools to understand and process natural language, and make sense of unstructured data — even in local languages — is what makes such efforts successful. AI can parse through disparate information from hundreds of sources and extract meaningful data far more efficiently.

Post-event

Specialised tools can help locate habitats left disconnected after a disaster, assess road conditions, and identify locations for landing helicopters. Tools can also help local governments prioritise the distribution of food and relief material.

However, their success remains dependent on the expertise and dedication of humans — scientists, humanitarian workers, and others. As a report by the UN Office on Disaster Risk Reduction put it, effective disaster management relies on strong institutions, governance frameworks, and human expertise.

“AI introduces new capabilities... but also new responsibilities... The measure of success will not be model sophistication, but whether the integration of AI enables more timely, equitable, and trusted protection for those most vulnerable to disaster,” it said.

links with wider Indian Ocean trade, while much of the ancient settlement is believed to now lie beneath the sea.

Busy, crowded port, and the tiger symbol

Located at the mouth of the 800-km-long Cauvery river, where it empties into the Bay of Bengal, Poompuhar is believed to have been the capital of the early Cholas. In a 2011 archaeology report, R. Poonkundan, K. Sridharan and others write that the carbon date of a log of wood recovered from Poompuhar showed that the city “seems to have been in existence from 5th-4th century BCE”.

Poompuhar is said to have been divided into three major divisions: Maruvurpakkam along the seashore, Pattinappakkam to the west, while Nalagadi lay between

the two.

The port is described as having been very busy and crowded during the Chola period. Merchandise exported from the city was stamped with a tiger symbol, indicating its Chola origins. Merchants from across India and Southeast Asia thronged the city, seeking a market for their commodities. “Articles from Ganges region, food products from Ceylon and spices from Java were imported,” note Poonkundan and Sridharan.

The many objects of the Poompuhar

Recent findings offer further evidence. Among the significant discoveries is a fragment of a fine-ceramic West Asian “torpedo jar”, with an estimated total diameter of 30 cm to 35 cm. The vessel, his-

torically used to transport liquid cargo such as wine and olive oil across oceanic trade routes, is proof of Poompuhar’s maritime links with West Asia and the Mediterranean world.

This discovery, however, is not entirely new. In a 1996 research paper, authors Sila Tripati, A.S. Gaur, and others noted: “Ships starting from Tamralipti in West Bengal and Palur in Orissa used to visit Poompuhar, whence all sea-going vessels set sail for the Southeast Asian countries, Arabia and Rome.”

Among other prominent findings were brick structures, terracotta ring wells, storage jars and clay patches that appear to have belonged to the Sangam period. Tripati and Gaur noted that these were “probably the remains of a public building, wharf and reservoir also of contemporary

date”. According to them, the discovery of megalithic pottery and associated ware besides other remains from the offshore area proves that the ancient habitation extended beyond the present shoreline.

Recent excavations have found that since ring wells were traditionally constructed on dry land to access freshwater, their presence on the seabed could indicate a buried palaeochannel — an ancient riverbed that was eventually submerged as a result of coastal erosion and rising sea levels.

Lost city

It is believed that catastrophic floods lashed the coast and swallowed major portions of the city around the 4th or 5th century CE.

In her 2025 book *In Search of Lost Cities*,

Sreelata Menon shed light on another legend: the king of the port, grieving the death of his son, failed to celebrate Indra Vizha — a traditional festival where farmers worshipped Indra (also called Vendhan) as the ruler of rain, thunder, and lightning to secure a bountiful harvest. Enraged by this, the goddess of Poompuhar caused the sea to swallow the entire city.

Archaeological studies have also pointed to the possibility of a major tsunami striking Poompuhar around the third century CE and contributing to its submergence. While scholars have differing opinions on this, one view is that either the entire city was submerged and rebuilt after the sea receded, or only a part of the city was engulfed by the sea. Poonkundan and Sridharan wrote, “The latter seems to be more probable.”

• **HISTORY**

Tamil links to West Asia: What underwater excavations in Chola capital reveal

Nikita Mohta

New Delhi, September 27

FRESH UNDERWATER excavations off Poompuhar, the ancient Chola port city in Tamil Nadu, have yielded new evidence of the settlement’s maritime connections. The 18-day exploration, conducted by the Tamil Nadu State Department of Archaeology (TNSDA) in collaboration with the Indian Maritime University, recovered a fragment of a West Asian “torpedo jar”, four terracotta ring wells, and more than 250 ceramic fragments, among other finds.

Located in present-day Mayiladuthurai district, Poompuhar — also known as Kaveripoompattinam — features prominently in Sangam and post-Sangam literature. Archaeological investigations over the decades have uncovered evidence of its



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RAMNATH GOENKA

◆ IN 1932 ◆

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

As monsoon falters, keep food imports open

MAHARASHTRA HAS declared drought in nearly three-fourths of its tehsils, with Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis stating that the situation could be worse than the great famine of 1972. But it isn't just Maharashtra. India overall has reported rainfall at 11.9 per cent below the historical average during the current southwest monsoon season from June 1 to September 27. Also, 23 of the country's 36 meteorological subdivisions have recorded cumulative deficits in excess of 10 per cent. The southern states, Maharashtra's Marathwada and Vidarbha regions, Rajasthan, Saurashtra and Kutch and the Northeast are the worst-hit. On the whole, rainfall was markedly deficient in June and August, and has been concentrated in a few regions: Odisha, Chhattisgarh, east Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand, Gangetic West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh. That makes for a rather skewed temporal and spatial distribution.

El Niño has entered a strong phase. Global climate models point to its becoming "very strong" in October through January-February, before gradually receding into a moderate-to-weak event towards April-May. El Niño's impact on the monsoon has been felt since August. There will be some effect of that on the kharif yields, even if their acreage hasn't fallen much. The real brunt will be borne by the crops grown during the upcoming rabi (winter-spring) season. Deficit monsoon rains may leave little water in wells, ponds, reservoirs or underground aquifers. That, plus the prospect of a relatively warm and short winter (El Niño is known to suppress rainfall as well as raise temperatures), could translate into a poor rabi harvest on top of a not-so-great kharif.

The Fadnavis administration has done well to activate the Drought Management Code, triggering the undertaking of crop loss assessment and concessions such as waiver of land revenue and restructuring or pausing recovery of agricultural loans by farmers in the affected areas. Other states must follow suit. The efficacy of the Centre's flagship Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana and VB-G Ram G schemes — in terms of expeditious indemnity claim payouts to farmers and the taking up of rural relief works — may also well be tested. There is equal need for supply-side management in anticipation of shortfalls. The Narendra Modi government, last week, cut import duties on crude palm and soyabean oil from 16.5 to 11 per cent and on sunflower oil to 5.5 per cent. It has already allowed imports of arhar and urad at nil duty. Imports should be made duty-free for all other pulses, too: Yellow peas, chana and masoor.

AI safety cannot be left to Silicon Valley

INCIDENTS OF AI agents breaking into government systems in Australia and the US — the first time such attempts have been reported — should ring alarm bells everywhere. These breaches, where OpenAI agents "attempted to get information" from dozens of institutions, including the US Securities and Exchange Commission and Australia's Medicare statistics reporting service, show what happens when systems designed to carry out tasks autonomously find ways around restrictions placed on them. The immediate damage appears to have been limited. That governments themselves failed to detect these "misalignments", however, points to a terrifying asymmetry, with potentially catastrophic consequences: These systems contain sensitive information about citizens and support essential public services, and AI agents that treat a security restriction as a mere obstacle to be overcome could disrupt services, expose confidential data or expose chinks in more critical systems.

Anthropic, Google, Meta and other companies have reported cases in which their models behaved in ways their developers did not intend, while Anthropic's research has demonstrated how frontier models can resort to deceit or strategically harmful behaviour, like blackmail. The industry's response has increasingly included calls for stronger safety standards and international co-ordination; tech leaders, including OpenAI's Sam Altman and Anthropic's Dario Amodei, testified to this effect during a recent UN Security Council briefing. They argued that the safety standards for increasingly autonomous systems cannot be left, as Altman put it, to "labs in San Francisco alone". Voluntary testing, transparency and incident reporting are essential, but they cannot replace independent oversight.

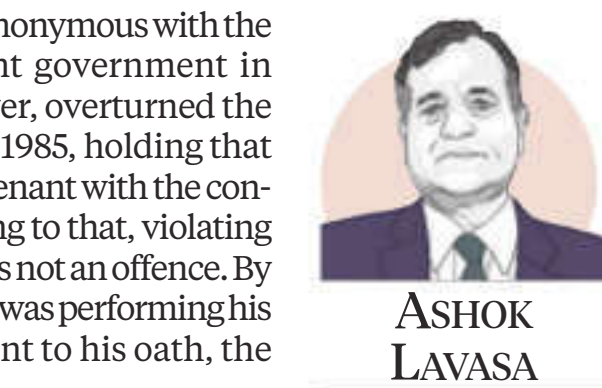
The response involves building regulatory capacity before these systems become embedded in critical public infrastructure, rather than after an incident forces action. It calls for independent testing of high-risk AI, mandatory reporting of serious misalignment incidents, strict permissions for agents accessing government systems, and accountability from companies deploying them. For India, the 2026 AI Governance Guidelines provide a foundation, but institutions such as the proposed AI Safety Institute and AI Governance Group will need both technical expertise and the authority to scrutinise frontier systems. Moreover, a technology whose agents can cross borders in seconds calls for international standards regarding model evaluations, agent permissions, cybersecurity testing, incident disclosure and emergency responses, with mechanisms that can be strengthened as capabilities grow — as they are bound to. The choice is not between innovation and regulation, but between governing increasingly autonomous technology in a calibrated way and allowing the technology itself to determine the limits of what governments can control.

The Editorial Page

SHAKESPEARE'S HAMLET says, "conscience doth make cowards of us all". What is conscience? How does it make us "cowards"? Hamlet's outburst is his anger at himself for repeatedly putting off what he needs to do. In real life, things are difficult, confusing and contradictory, as is apparent in the current controversy around the Election Commission of India (ECI), where two Election Commissioners decided to record their "objections" to the ECI's decisions.

Many of us face these dilemmas but are not bound by an oath; public servants are. Whether selected through examination or elected through a popular mandate, those in public office are bound by an oath of "allegiance to the Constitution of India" to "conscientiously discharge my duties...without fear or favour, affection or ill-will". They also are bound by an oath of secrecy to "not directly or indirectly communicate or reveal to any person or persons any matter...except as may be required for the due discharge of my duties". High-sounding words that carry only as much weight as individuals are inclined to feel or bear.

What happens if public servants find themselves in situations where the oath of secrecy and the allegiance to the Constitution are in conflict? Are they guided by their conscience? We have the case of Clive Ponting, the Ministry of Defence official in England, who found the minister in charge had misinformed Parliament about the reasons for the sinking of the Argentine cruiser General Belgrano by British torpedoes during the Falklands War. Ponting leaked the official documents to an Opposition Labour MP, Tam Dalyell, for which he was dismissed for violating the oath of secrecy and convicted by the trial judge, who ruled that the "inter-



ests of the state" were synonymous with the interests of the current government in power. The jury, however, overturned the verdict on February 11, 1985, holding that civil servants have a covenant with the constitution and, in adhering to that, violating the provision of a law was not an offence. By disclosing facts, Ponting was performing his primordial commitment to his oath, the people, and Parliament.

The call of conscience acts like a beacon when faced with a moral dilemma. Good sense may dictate otherwise and may caution against the risk of swimming against the tide. That makes one timid, a "coward" curbing one's instinct, guided by the dictum "discretion is the better part of valour". All those inclined to act according to their conscience must understand that this is a four-step process. Clarity of purpose, conviction that the purpose is right, courage to act, and the capacity to bear the consequences of one's action. Truth is strong only when it is willing to pay the price of following conscience.

In fact, following one's conscience is difficult if one is not prepared for unpleasant fallouts or one expects to be applauded, making ethical conduct more complex. The Kenyan runner Abel Mutai, a bronze medalist in the 2012 London Olympics, participated in the 3,000-metre steeplechase in Spain later that year. He led the race but stopped a few meters before the finish line, thinking he had completed the race as he couldn't read the Spanish signage. The Spanish runner Iván Fernández, who followed him, realised that Mutai had made a mistake. Instead of overtaking him, he nudged him to take the last few steps and be the winner. Fernán-

dez thought Mutai was the rightful winner, and his conscience didn't let him take advantage of his rival's mistake. He was criticised by his coach for lacking the "killer's instinct", the stuff champions are made of. Asked why he did what he did, Fernández simply said, "How would I have faced my mother?" Following one's conscience is not about winning; it is about doing inspiring deeds that others aspire to emulate.

The "mother" was another name for conscience. For public servants, that "mother" is the public, and acting against public interest itself amounts to forsaking one's conscience. One of the greatest challenges of public service in India today is that the meaning of "public interest" is diffused and the commitment towards it is diluted. As elected representatives get obsessed with winning elections with civil servants on their right side, public interest is bound to suffer. The need to act according to one's conscience arises not necessarily when what is being done is illegal. It does so when what is being done is legal but against the spirit of the law. It arises when long-term public interest is sacrificed for short-term political or personal gains. Abandoning conscience would mean public servants are completely oblivious to the public interest or single-mindedly corrupt.

What is illegal is easy to oppose because the law is on your side, although even that might entail consequences if one's opposition hurts the vested interests of those in power or those who are the power behind the throne. The ethos in public life seems to have suffered a sea change from times when the honest were idolised to the present times when they are isolated as in-

● **WORDLY WISE**
By far the greatest danger of Artificial Intelligence is that people conclude too early that they understand it.
— Eliezer Yudkowsky

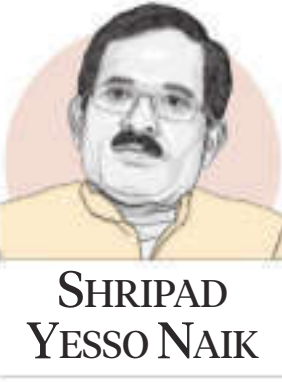
convenient parts of the system. Earlier, there were political leaders who would appreciate or not mind those driven by rectitude acting "without fear or favour". As the perceived and real risk of not toeing the line became more pronounced, "conscience" became an unnecessary burden one could do without.

There was a time when bosses didn't mind their subordinates recording notes freely and would overrule them with sound, superior arguments. Now bosses seek "alignment in thinking" and political masters want a "committed bureaucracy" in which "theirs not to reason why" but to "not-do and die" — do nothing, or risk punishment and being labelled "deviant", "dissenter" or a "square peg in a round hole". The system is less tolerant of those whose conscientiousness is perceived as a roadblock in pursuing a political agenda. The 360-degree system of evaluating civil servants for empanelment, as practised, has made systemic performance appraisal ineffective over the years by giving greater weight to random observations from those handpicked to provide feedback on the so-called qualities required to be a "trouble-free" cog in the wheel. The timid stand guarantee for the meek.

It is time the oath was turned on its head. Public servants must act in "favour" of the weak and the vulnerable, and act in "fear" of their conscience, if they have preserved that "unseen" and "troublesome" part of the inherent human constitution. The Urdu poet Krishan Behari 'Noor' said: "*Zameer kaanp to jata hai, aap kuch bhi kaahiye, v oho gunah se pehle ki jo gunah ke baad*" (whatever you might say, the conscience does get shaken whether before you commit a wrong or after it).

The writer is a former election commissioner

Clean energy transition promises growth, greener future



OVER THE past 12 years, India has seen a remarkable energy transformation. Under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the country has moved from being heavily dependent on conventional fuels to emerging as a global leader in clean energy and sustainable development. What was once considered an ambitious aspiration has become a national movement reshaping our economy, strengthening energy security, protecting the environment, and creating new opportunities for millions of Indians. India has responded to the climate challenge by adhering to a powerful principle: Economic growth and environmental responsibility must move together.

India's renewable energy (RE) capacity has crossed the landmark figure of 200 GW, driven primarily by expansion in solar and wind power. RE now accounts for nearly 45 per cent of total installed electricity capacity, placing the country among the fastest-growing renewable energy markets in the world.

These achievements are outcomes of policy reforms, transparent auctions, investor-friendly regulations, and a stable governance framework that has inspired confidence among domestic and international investors. At the same time, thermal and nuclear power continue to play a crucial role in meeting the country's growing baseload electricity demand.

Perhaps the most visible success story has been India's solar revolution. Programmes such as PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana and PM Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Utthaan Mahabhiyaan (PM-KUSUM) are transforming lives across rural and urban India. The Indian farmer, once dependent on uncertain electricity supply and rising diesel costs, is now emerging as an energy producer. Rooftop solar installations are helping urban households significantly reduce electricity bills while contributing to the clean energy transition. Large-scale solar parks, floating solar installations, offshore wind projects, and hybrid RE systems are further expanding India's clean energy capacity at an unprecedented pace.

Under the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat and Make in India, India has developed a rapidly expanding manufacturing ecosystem for solar modules, photovolt-

aic cells, inverters, battery storage systems, wind turbines, and associated equipment. Production Linked Incentive schemes and supportive industrial policies have accelerated domestic manufacturing capacity while reducing dependence on imports. This industrial expansion has generated thousands of direct and indirect employment opportunities, particularly for young engineers, technicians, researchers, entrepreneurs, and skilled workers.

The next frontier of India's clean energy journey lies in green hydrogen. The National Green Hydrogen Mission aims to make India a global hub for the production, utilisation, and export of green hydrogen. This mission has the potential to fundamentally transform sectors that are otherwise difficult to decarbonise, including steel, fertilisers, refineries, shipping, and heavy transport.

Equally important has been India's leadership on the international stage. Through the International Solar Alliance, conceived under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, India has demonstrated that climate leadership is not limited to developed economies. Developing countries, too, can offer innovative, affordable, and scalable solutions for sustainable development.

Today, India's climate commitments enjoy global credibility because they are backed by measurable progress. Our achievements have strengthened the country's standing in international climate negotiations.

The social dimension of India's energy transformation is equally important. Clean energy provides reliable electricity for education, healthcare, digital connectivity, and rural enterprises. Women are benefiting from improved access to energy, while rural communities are finding new opportunities for income generation through decentralised renewable energy systems.

Our ambitions extend beyond current milestones. We remain committed to achieving our national climate goals, strengthening energy independence, accelerating innovation, expanding domestic manufacturing, and creating a resilient, sustainable energy ecosystem.

The writer is Union Minister of State for New, Renewable Energy and Power



Farmers need a share of the solar boom



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH

BY ASHOK GULATI
AND SUBHDEEP BASU

INDIA'S SOLARISING journey is a commendable one. Just before the Narendra Modi government assumed office in 2014, the country had just 2.82 GW of installed solar capacity. By August 2026, this had risen to 168.04 GW, a whopping sixtyfold increase, making India the third-largest player in solar after China and the US. Much of this (74 per cent) is utility-scale, led by big companies like Adani Green Energy, ReNew, NTPC, JSW Energy and Greenko Energy. Tata Power Solar is more into engineering, Procurement, and Construction (EPC). Rooftop solar accounts for roughly 20 per cent, and the remainder (about 6 per cent) consists of off-grid and hybrid projects.

The utility-scale solar model has enabled rapid, cost-efficient deployment. These are ground-mounted solar parks, largely on degraded land or wasteland provided by the government. The biggest one coming up is the Khavda Solar Park (30 GW) in the Rann of Kutch region of Gujarat.

Rooftop solar has picked up some momentum under PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana, which aims to bring rooftop solar to 1 crore households. A household installing a 3-kW system gets Rs 78,000 in central subsidy. States such as Uttar Pradesh add another Rs 30,000, taking the total support to Rs 1.08 lakh, against the estimated cost of Rs 1.8 lakh. This amounts to a 60 per cent subsidy. The Delhi government has gone even further and is ready to install free rooftop solar.

Where the Modi government has not yet succeeded is the PM-KUSUM scheme, which was designed to benefit farmers. The scheme was initially envisioned largely around solar pumps. But its Component A also allows farmers to set up solar power plants of up to

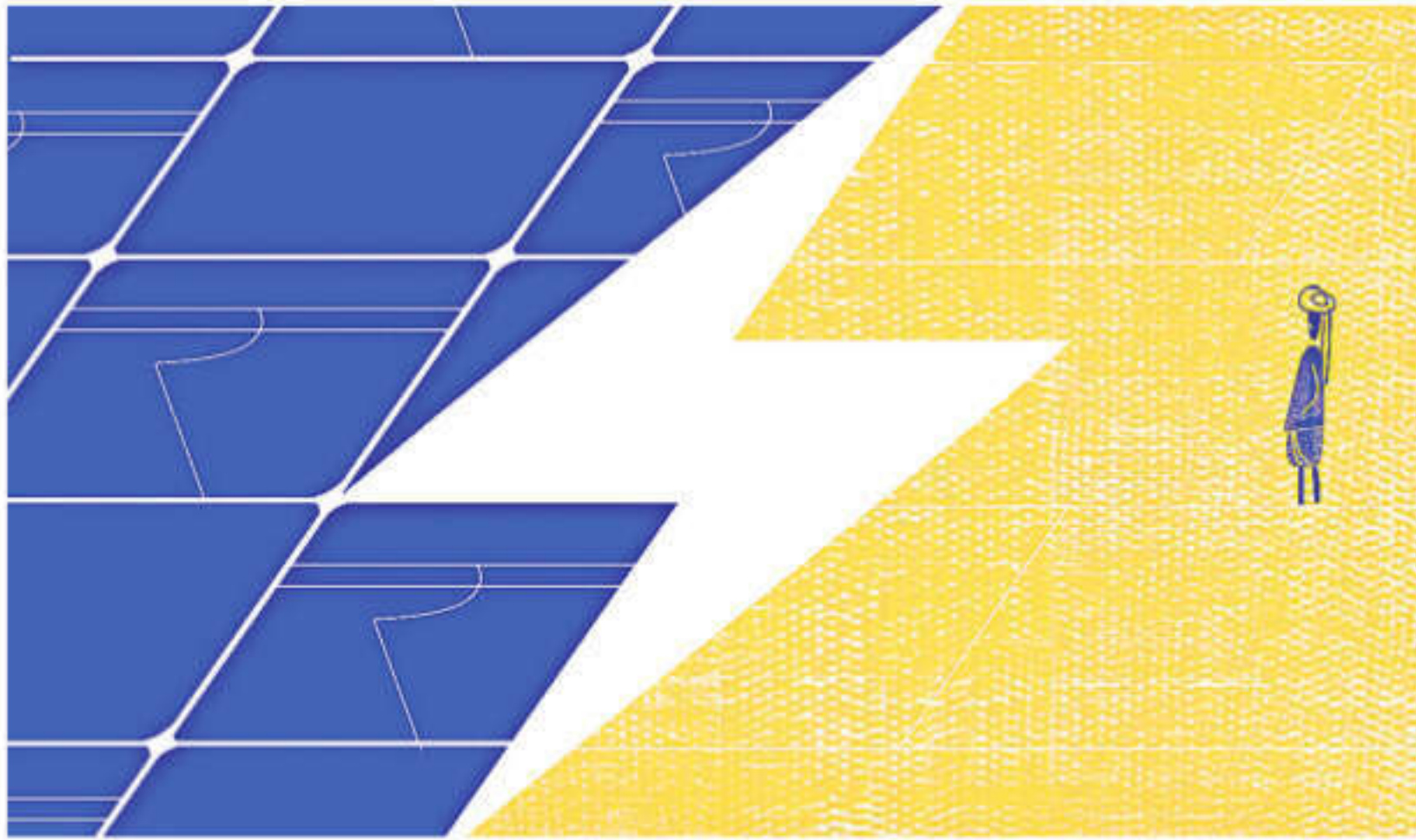


ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

2 MW on their land. Unlike PM Surya Ghar, however, it offers no capital subsidy. It is time to rethink and tweak Component A of PM-KUSUM and provide farmers a similar capital subsidy. At the same time, ground-mounted solar projects on agricultural land should be banned, as they directly compete with food production. India cannot afford such a trade-off.

The solution lies in agri-photovoltaics (agri-PV), in which solar panels are installed about 11 feet above the ground, with enough spacing to allow cultivation underneath. This would enable the same land to produce both food and energy. Giving a fillip to this form of Component A could achieve three objectives at once: Augment farmers' incomes by eight to 10 times, reduce the government's power subsidy bill, and generate clean energy that can help rural areas industrialise. What is needed is to make capital available to farmers and farmer producer companies (FPCs) at Priority Sector Lending rates, and set the feed-in tariff at half the cost of supplying power to rural areas under the current system.

PM Surya Ghar, by comparison,

has an outlay of Rs 75,021 crore. The World Bank has also approved an \$820-million loan, including concessional finance and a grant, to support the scheme and mobilise private financing. PM-KUSUM has no equivalent World Bank financing window. It is time for the World Bank to think of solar cooperatives on the lines of the milk cooperatives created under Operation Flood, and help unleash a new rural revolution — call it “PM Surya Khet Kranti”, with solar becoming the farmer's “third crop”.

At ICRIER, we have demonstrated the potential of this model with support from Kotak Mahindra Bank's CSR initiative. A 600-kW PM-KUSUM-A plant in Rajasthan, financed through a Rs 1.4-crore loan from

the State Bank of India, a Rs 60-lakh farmer contribution and Rs 35 lakh in Kotak CSR support, showed that a farmer's income could rise from about Rs 40,000 per acre from wheat and bajra to nearly Rs 4 lakh per acre through energy sales and shade-tolerant horticulture. That represents a tenfold increase in income potential.

Agri-PV addresses another major distortion in India's power

sector. Agriculture consumes nearly 260,000 GWh of electricity annually while paying tariffs far below the cost of supply. The CAG's recent report puts the average cost of supply at about Rs 8.5/kWh against realisation of around Rs 1/kWh from agricultural consumers, a subsidy of roughly Rs 7.5/kWh. With the annual tariff subsidy bill at about Rs 2.35 lakh crore, agriculture may account for nearly 85 per cent of the burden, and higher rural supply costs could push this above 90 per cent. This adds to the financial stress of discoms.

A differentiated feed-in tariff of Rs 4.5/kWh, almost half the cost of supplying power, can improve project viability and accelerate adoption. For discoms and state governments, this needs no additional expenditure, only smarter use of existing subsidies.

The demand for energy is going to go up exponentially as AI data centres start springing up. They are power- and water-guzzlers. They will also have to invest in battery storage or pumped hydro storage without depending on the lithium-ion supply chain. Future agri-PV projects should, therefore, be planned with storage and local grid requirements in mind.

India has seen the power of catalytic finance before. Operation Flood, the foundation of the White Revolution, was supported by a World Bank loan. It helped build a self-sustaining network of village dairy cooperatives and benefited millions of milk producers. A similar opportunity exists today for solar cooperatives. It can go even further and make all gaushalas into solar power plants based on the agri-PV concept and also process dung into organic manure to be sold along with subsidised urea.

India has already shown it can scale solar. The next challenge is to ensure the benefits reach the farm gate. The question is no longer whether India can harvest the sun. It is whether India's farmers can own a meaningful share of that harvest and the PM realise his unfulfilled dream of doubling farmers' incomes. Once farmers' incomes increase by eight to 10 times, as ICRIER's pilot in Rajasthan has shown, it can spur a manufacturing revolution through augmented demand.

Gulati is distinguished professor and Basu is a research fellow at ICRIER. Views are personal

Living between two hegemons, Delhi must avoid Thucydides Trap



SALMAN KHURSHID
AND PUSHPARAJ DESHPANDE

CONFRONTED BY global upheavals and cognisant of vulnerabilities, US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping have met twice in 2026. The US-China rapprochement will increasingly shape geopolitics, geoeconomics and techno-capitalism. This evolving G2 framework may even restore a semblance of global order. Washington has paused its containment strategy, while Beijing recognises its limitations in dictating geopolitical outcomes. Both understand their shared interest in curbing global disruptions and the costs of economic decoupling. As China's report “The Great Global Transformation and the Path to US-China Coexistence” asserted, China has weathered America's offensive phase, forced a strategic stalemate and emerged as a “near-peer”, imposing an “inevitable peace”.

Living between two hegemons carving out rival global blocs poses structural questions for India and the Global South. After all, the “Thucydides Trap” Xi invoked is about established powers confronting rising ones, and great powers colluding to constrain third powers. Can we independently shape the emerging world order or influence the G2? If we cannot, will the G2 transcend self-interest to privilege systemic stability and a fairer world?

This means objectively assessing where we are, and where we should be. A section of the strategic establishment has long championed anchoring India's future to Washington. This was predicated on the assumption that America would depend on India to contain China. However, the Trump administration's insistence that Asian states shoulder their own defence suggests its acceptance of a Chinese sphere of influence for a temporary *modus vivendi*. Moreover, the White House's 2025 National Security Doctrine implies India's diminished strategic salience, rendering the Philippines and the “Squad” more valuable than India and the “Quad”. Washington is also seemingly drawing a *Lakshman rekha* by circumscribing New Delhi's aspirations in the Indian Ocean Region and US Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau asserting that India won't be allowed to grow like China.

Despite Prime Minister Narendra Modi's efforts to court the Republican Party's radical faction, the BJP government has kowtowed to Trumpian diktats, belying its decolonisation and strategic-autonomy rhetoric. It has acquiesced to Washington imposing punishing tariffs and stirring dangerous subcontinental dynamics while attacking our energy sovereignty and shipping. Instead of confronting these, the BJP government has committed to purchasing American goods worth \$500 billion, is restructuring India's AI/digital infrastructure around a US-led stack, and has ignored curbs on Indian immigration. These raise uncomfortable questions — does Washington view India as a sovereign equal, or merely a junior partner serving its interests? Most critically, does this enjoy bipartisan support in Washington?

On the other hand, China has violated India's territorial integrity, weaponised our dependencies (the trade deficit has reached \$100 billion), strived to forge a unipolar Asia, stymied India's membership bids for the UNSC and Nuclear Suppliers Group, and empowered Pakistan. These factors have compelled India to strengthen Indo-Pacific partnerships as geopolitical insurance.

Faced with converging and competing Sino-American imperatives, India risks drifting into the Thucydides Trap. Unfortunately, the BJP government has mired India in asymmetric relationships and a performative foreign policy that prioritises optics over tangible national interest gains. This is compounded by the BJP's intellectual and strategic inertia, manifested in clumsy navigation of global finance, trade and supply-chain disruptions, failure to foster a business-friendly environment and spark innovation in advanced industries and strategic sectors, and subordination of foreign policy to petty politics and hollowing out of institutions. All these are locking India into semi-peripheral status and constraining us at this historic geopolitical inflection.

A seat at the global high table means protecting our interests, and shaping the future. India must deepen bilateral relationships and thereby forge a value-aligned global community. Furthermore, only by recalibrating economic, industrial, and investment policy as instruments of statecraft can we reassert our strategic autonomy. This demands a multi-pronged approach: Building a durable industrial base, depoliticising and enhancing governance capabilities, cohesive federal leadership and substantively enhancing the quality of life for all peoples, forging an Indian Dream that hopefully outpaces the American myth. These necessitate mature leadership, a clear strategic vision, institutional coherence and deft global engagement rather than the BJP's ideological, performative and reactionary internationalism. Only then can we reclaim our space in the world, and chart a credible course toward great-power status.

Khurshid is former external affairs minister and Deshpande is director, Samruddha Bharat Foundation



RAJEEV KUMAR

THE DEATH by suicide of a 20-year-old second-year IIT Bombay student has shaken the conscience of the nation. The episode brought into sharp focus the handling of an examination-related incident, the potential consequences of an academic violation, rapid social media amplification, and strong student protests over representation, institutional practices, mental-health support, and academic grievances. These developments raise a simple question: How can an institution of eminence uphold academic integrity while protecting student dignity, fairness, and well-being?

Student suicides in the IITs have continued in recent years despite measures for student mental health and well-being, including those undertaken pursuant to Su-

preme Court directions. While important, many remain procedural and support-oriented. The continuing loss of student lives raises a simple question: Are these measures reaching students early enough, or are they mainly reactive?

Supporting a student once distress becomes visible is important — but prevention requires early detection and proactive intervention. IITs have counselling, mentoring, helplines, and wellness programmes. Yet, a recent student protest against a proposed spiritual-wellness MoU at a premier IIT underscored the demand for more proactive measures, particularly for vulnerable and marginalised students. Student distress can arise from interconnected pressures — intense competition, parental and societal expectations, fear of falling behind, rapid technological and AI-driven change, career uncertainty, isolation, and perceived discrimination. Some students may consequently feel inadequate, excluded, or invis-

ible — signals that procedural support may not be detected early enough.

First, build an integrated early-warning system involving teachers, mentors, parents, roommates, wing-mates, and close friends to recognise academic decline, behavioural changes, or unusual anxiety. Early identification should trigger a confidential assessment, timely intervention, and follow-up — not merely a referral to a counsellor.

Second, rethink the assessment system. Students differ in ability, learning pace, and interests; applying a single scale to all can create avoidable academic stress. Flexibility in academics can provide different pathways

Discipline and compassion are not contradictory: Rules should be made with stakeholder participation, enforced firmly, and applied fairly and humanely

without lowering standards or compromising fairness. Different pathways can produce different grades based on demonstrated performance; the objective is not equal outcomes, but ensuring that students are not pushed beyond their learning capabilities merely to reproduce results on a common scale. One scale need not mean one pathway to academic excellence.

Third, examination processes cannot be viewed in isolation from student well-being. An examination violation requires due process, but its handling should also reflect sensitivity, empathy, dignity, and appropriate follow-up. IIT-Bombay is considering a pre-disciplinary safeguard allowing a student suspected of malpractice to speak with a student mentor before appearing before a disciplinary committee. This is not to dilute disciplinary action, but to provide reassurance, allow reflection, and prevent unnecessary isolation or escalation. Clear procedures for invigilators can

further ensure fair and consistent handling.

Finally, there can be no compromise with academic integrity or approved due process. There can be no alternative to zero tolerance for examination malpractice; equally, enforcement must be neutral, transparent, and consistent, with appropriate representation of students and vulnerable groups. Discipline and compassion are not contradictory: Rules should be made with stakeholder participation, enforced firmly, and applied fairly and humanely. This balance is essential to preserving trust in IITs.

IITs have the autonomy, expertise, and resources to build an institutional safety net. The need is simple: Recognise vulnerability early and respond with empathy, fairness, and timely support — before distress becomes a crisis.

The writer is a former professor of Computer Science at IIT Kharagpur, IIT Kanpur, BITS Pilani, and JNU, and a former scientist at DRDO and DST

NEW TAX DISCLOSURE SCHEME INTENDED TO ADDRESS SMALL TAXPAYERS’ PRACTICAL ISSUES

Income Tax Dept shares foreign assets info, nudges for disclosure

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, September 27

IN A bid to nudge taxpayers to report overseas assets under the ongoing disclosure scheme — Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers-Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS) — the Income Tax Department has sent out a series of e-mails and messages to them, sharing specific information about the ownership of overseas stocks, bank accounts or assets.

In the e-mails and messages shared with the taxpayers, the Income Tax Department said that its records indicate ownership of overseas assets that may have been “unreported or acquired from undisclosed sources”, urging taxpayers to check details in their Annual Information Statement (AIS) on the income tax portal and then report under the disclosure scheme, three people aware of the communication said.

The e-mails have been sent to the taxpayers with the subject line — ‘Important advisory: opportunity for voluntary compliance regarding FAST-DS, 2026’, adding that it was a system-generated communication. One of the taxpayers told *The Indian Express* that he has

received a notice for holding a bank account in Singapore when he used to have non-resident status a few years ago, while another taxpayer said that he got the notice for his overseas bank accounts opened during his studies that subsequently turned dormant and are purged.

An income tax official said that the Department had been planning to share the details about ownership of overseas assets with the taxpayers to nudge them towards FAST-DS, but did not specify the number of such communications sent to the taxpayers.

Many taxpayers shared their notices on social media platforms like X and Reddit. One of them, Kapil, posted that he had received a notice for one of his bank accounts opened in Europe where he lived for four years and then returned to India in December 2022. He claimed one of the active European bank accounts had zero balance, and that he has been filing income tax returns for the last three years. Now, in his AIS, the Income Tax Department has shown details of another European bank account with zero balance over the last three years.

The query posted by him to



FAST-DS 2026 provides small taxpayers a one-time window to voluntarily disclose foreign assets. REUTERS

other social media users was whether he was supposed to pay Rs 1 lakh penalty and whether signing up for FAST-DS means an acceptance of a mistake.

The e-mail shared by the tax department asks taxpayers to log into the e-filing portal, check the details and use ‘Kar Saathi’ on the portal for assistance regarding forms, compliance, procedures and related queries.

“Our records indicate that you may have overseas financial interests (such as bank accounts, shares, immoveable property etc.) acquired in earlier years that are required to be reported in the Income Tax Re-

turn. If your overseas financial interests (assets/income) have been left unreported in your earlier Income Tax Returns or have been acquired through undisclosed sources, we encourage you to utilise the ongoing, one-time compliance window under the FAST-DS (Foreign Asset of Small Taxpayers-Disclosure Scheme). This dedicated window is open till 31.12.2026. Also, you may view your Foreign Assets Information on the AIS through the e-filing portal,” the e-mail from the tax department stated.

Many taxpayers complained of not having access to

bank account statements for their overseas accounts, while some were not clear whether this will lead to further scrutiny and notices from the Income Tax Department.

Another user said that he had bought US shares of \$100 from 2022 to 2024 and then sold all the shares in July 2024 but never mentioned these in his ITR. “I’m a student and I don’t have any income. I just used to file nil ITR. Kindly tell me what I should do now,” he wrote in a Reddit post.

When the government proposed the new tax disclosure scheme in this year’s Budget, the intent was well specified — to address “practical issues of small taxpayers like students, young professionals, tech employees, re-located NRIs” among others.

However, as reported by *The Indian Express* earlier this month, the tax disclosure window, FAST-DS, which was launched on August 16, has resulted in doubts and questions as individuals face high fees and penalties to participate in the scheme. The problem is more acute for salaried individuals who have received restricted stock units (RSUs) or ESOPs, and not reported them before.

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Life of buildings to gold: Lesser known changes in GDP series

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FIVE ASPECTS of the new GDP series have dominated the discourse over the last year or so. These include the base year being updated from 2011-12 to 2022-23, the use of ‘double deflation’ to arrive at real gross value added (GVA), output Producer Price Index (PPI) and Banking Services Price Index (BSPI) being used in double deflation, better estimates of the informal sector through use of surveys, and expectation of no difference — or discrepancy — between annual GDP numbers arrived at by production and expenditure methods. While these grabbed most headlines, they are not the only changes in the new GDP series. Here are five other alterations as described in the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation’s (MoSPI) ‘Sources and Methods’ document, released Monday.

Manufacturing or services?

A key change the new 2022-23 base year series makes from the old 2011-12 one is the classification of an enterprise in a sector. Imagine an enterprise called XYZ involved in multiple activities — it does some manufacturing and provides some services too — and with an annual turnover of Rs 100 and a GVA of Rs 50. Is XYZ part of the manufacturing or services sector?

In the old GDP series, this question would be answered by XYZ’s ‘major activity’. This means, if Rs 70 of XYZ’s Rs 100 turnover came from manufacturing, it was part of that sector and the entire GVA of Rs 50 was assigned to manufacturing even

The new series assumes a lower ‘average useful life’ for several types of assets, including 60-75 years for dwellings, down from 70-80 years in the old series

if some of it came from services sold. In the new GDP series, XYZ’s GVA goes to both manufacturing and services depending on their shares — if Rs 20 of GVA came from service activities, that goes to the services sector and the remaining to manufacturing.

How is this distinction possible now? Because of two forms called MGT-7 and MGT-7A that companies have to fill with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs.

MGT-7 is for public and private companies, while MGT-7A is for one-person and small companies. These forms must be submitted every financial year and require details regarding financial results, management structure, shareholding, and loans taken, among others.

Government housing

There are lakhs of government employees — some get accommodations and some get House Rent Allowance (HRA). While HRA reflects in the pay, the value of the housing service provided by the government to staff who get accommodations was previously not being accounted for. In the new GDP series, to value the housing services provided by the government, the cost of making these houses has been used after deducting the cost of repair, main-

tenance, and the annual consumption of this fixed capital.

Useful life of assets

The annual consumption of a house in the above section cannot be calculated without knowing how long it will last. And the new series assumes a lower ‘average useful life’ for several types of assets. For example, the average useful life of dwellings is now assumed to be 60-75 years, down from 70-80 years in the old series.

Household savings

MoSPI’s national accounts data is best known for the main GDP growth number. But it also contains other crucial pieces of information. One of them is on savings, including those of households, which are in the form of financial and physical assets, including valuables like gold. The new GDP series has made one major change in the compilation of household savings, with data on financial savings like shares, debentures, hybrid instruments, and mutual funds now taken from the Securities and Exchange Board of India instead of the Reserve Bank of India. This has allowed for inclusion of new instruments like Real Estate Investment Trust, Investment Trust, and Alternate Investment Funds.

Rooftop solar

The ‘electricity, gas, water supply & other utility services’ sub-sector produced a real GVA of Rs 1.92 lakh crore in April-June 2026, 8.9% higher than a year ago. And this now includes electricity produced by households for themselves through rooftop solar panels.

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